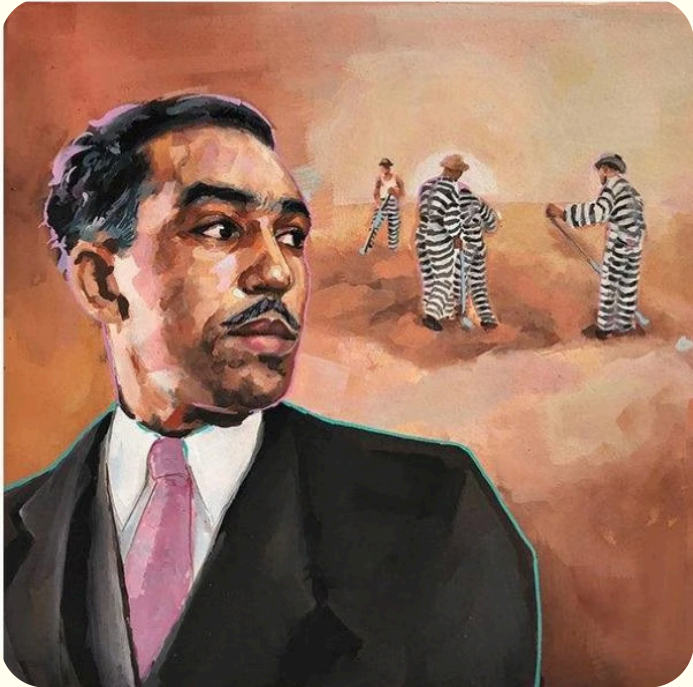


A Lost Voice Recovered: Langston Hughes and the Chain Gang Essay

An unknown 1933 essay — buried for decades, never published in English — and the story of racial injustice it refused to let the world forget.



A Discovery Hidden in Plain Sight



Historian **Steven Hoelscher** unearthed a searing, previously unknown Hughes essay buried in an unrelated archive at the **Harry Ransom Center, UT Austin**.

- Not even Hughes' authoritative biographer **Arnold Rampersad** could identify the manuscript
- Written in **1933** — never published in English until **2019**
- A major literary recovery hiding in plain sight for over 85 years

The Harlem Renaissance Road Trip, 1927

The Journey South

Hughes traveled by train through Louisiana, Mississippi, and Alabama to give poetry readings at Black universities.

A Fortuitous Meeting

In Mobile, he encountered **Zora Neale Hurston** — described as "one of the more fortuitous meetings in American literary history."

The Road Home

The pair drove back to New York together in Hurston's small Nash coupe — Hurston kept a **chrome-plated pistol** within reach for protection.



Driving Through Jim Crow America

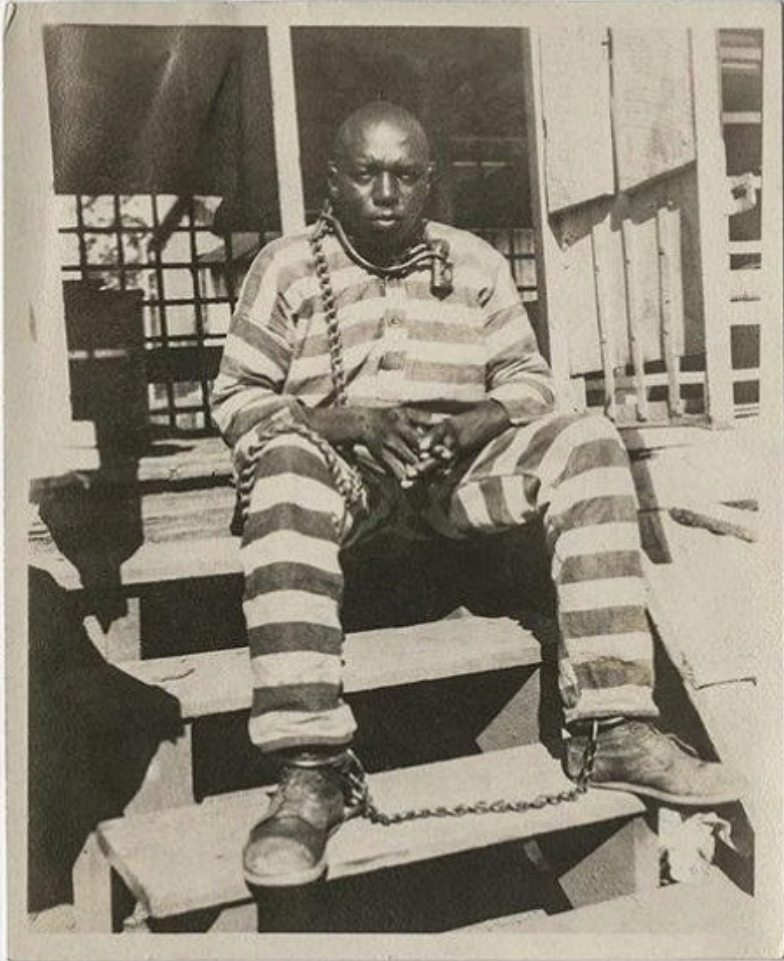


Along the highway, Hughes and Hurston passed **two chain gangs** — Black men in gray-and-black-striped suits laboring under armed white guards on horseback.

"We knew it was dangerous for Northern Negroes to appear too interested in the affairs of the rural South."

Their **New York license plate** made them conspicuous outsiders. They drove past without stopping — the risk was too great.

The Fugitive in the Swamp



The Encounter

Near Savannah at dusk, a young Black man waved frantically from the roadside swamp. He had **escaped the chain gang** and had not eaten in two days.

His Story

Picked up for fighting and sentenced to hard labor — married only **two weeks** before being sent away. He desperately wanted to reach his wife in Atlanta.

Survival

A Black preacher had given him clothes to disguise himself. He hid his face whenever cars passed on the road.

The Offer of Freedom — and a Disappearance

Hughes and Hurston urged the young man to come North with them:

"New York, where there are no chain gangs, and Negroes are not treated so badly."

He agreed. But by **dawn, he had vanished** — likely heading south toward Atlanta instead, back toward his wife.

"Perhaps the desire to go home had been greater than the wish to go North to freedom."



The Chain Gang: Slavery by Another Name

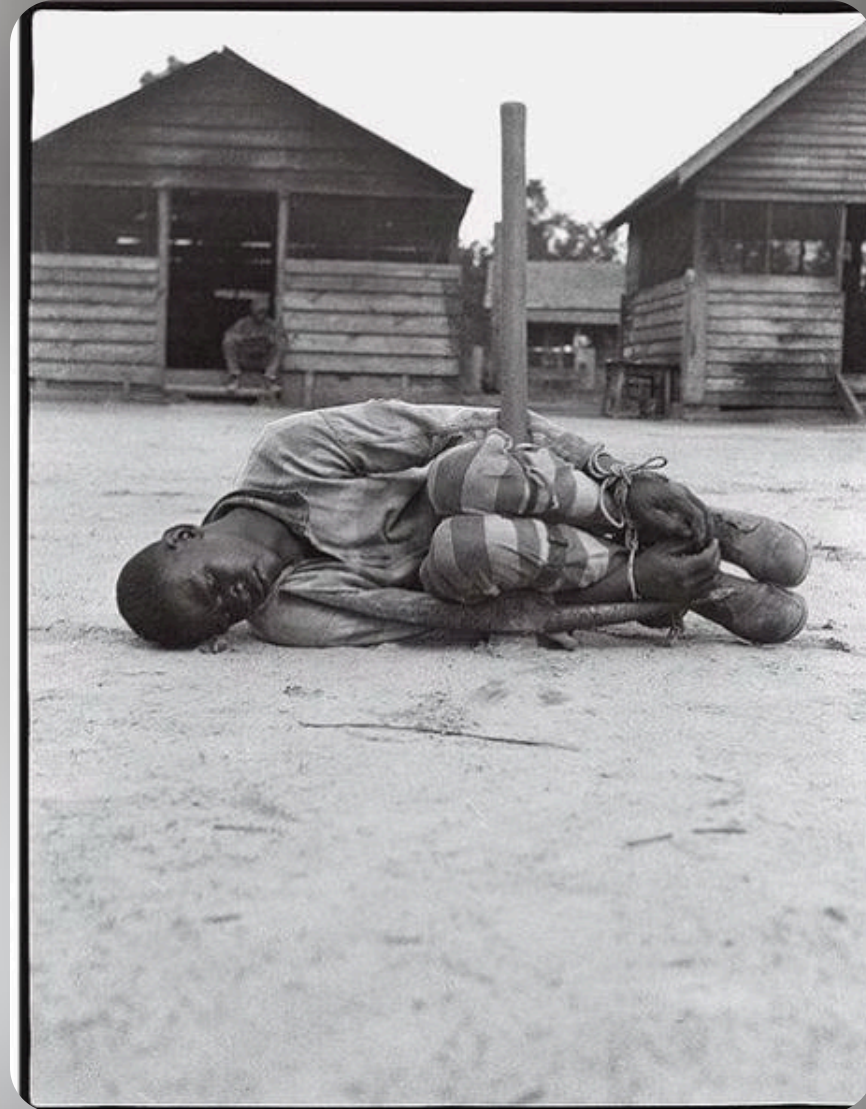
Scholars describe the forced labor system as **"a form of slavery by another name"** — Black men imprisoned on trivial charges and leased out as cheap labor.

The Exposé

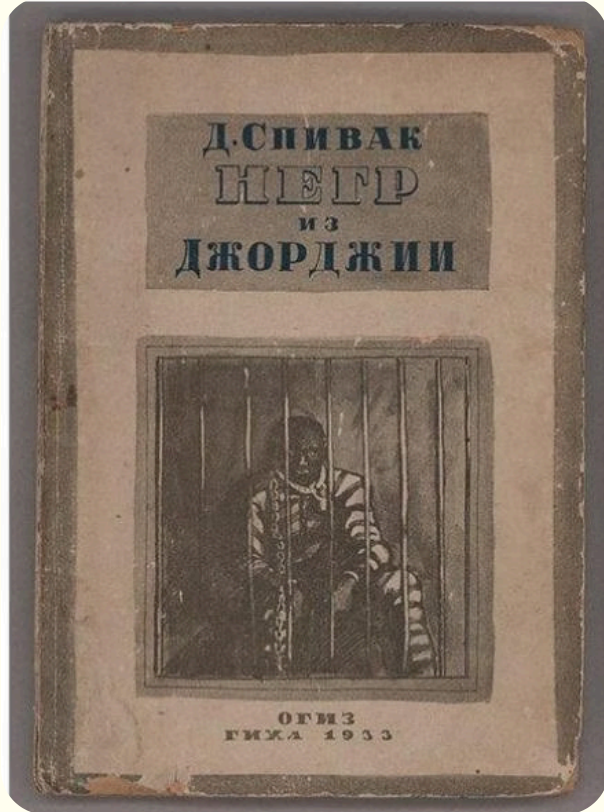
Investigative journalist **John L. Spivak** documented the atrocities in his 1932 book *Georgia Nigger* — photographs revealed men in neck irons and boys immobilized as punishment.

The System

Minor offenses became pretexts for imprisonment. Convicts were leased to farms and road crews under brutal conditions with little legal recourse.



Why the Essay Was Written — and Lost



Hughes wrote the essay in early **1933 from Moscow**, where he was celebrated as a "revolutionary writer" and could finally earn a living from his writing alone.

- Commissioned as the **foreword to the Soviet edition** of Spivak's book
- Published only in Russian — **never included** in English copies
- The Soviet Union's promotion of racial equality held deep appeal for Hughes, who **longed for it in America**

□ The essay's silence in English was not neglect — it was a consequence of Cold War politics and the geography of publication.

Hughes' Legacy: Giving Voice to the Forgotten

The young man in the swamp may have been **Ed Pinkney** — named in Hughes' journal — but his fate after that night remains **unknown**.

Hughes on Spivak

Hughes wrote that Spivak had "*blazed the way to truth*" — producing a volume "*of great importance to the Negro peoples.*"

The Urgency Today

By telling this story, Hughes forces us to reckon with the countless lives erased by systemic racism — a question as urgent in 2024 as it was in 1933.

